

DONATING A WOMB

Anand in Gujarat has become the centre for surrogacy. The number of successful deliveries is the highest in the world as childless couples and destitute women both find hope.

■ By Uday Mahurkar

Childless even after six years of marriage, a desperate Thomas Kim, 35, a loan manager in a bank in California, and his wife Karen, 34, decided to get a child by a surrogate mother, through a private US agency, for \$150,000 (Rs 60 lakh). Just before they were to sign the deal, Thomas read a front-page news report in *The Los Angeles Times* on how poor women were lending their wombs to childless couples in Anand, a small town in Gujarat, thanks to the efforts of gynaecologist Naina Patel. The couple got in touch with Patel and last February, Regina Malik, 29, wife of a factory employee, delivered their son, Brady, at Patel's Akanksha Fertility Clinic, for just over \$12,000 (Rs 5 lakh).

Today, the couple can't take their eyes off Brady, who looks every bit their child—like Karen, he has a dimple on his cheek, and his eyes resemble Thomas's. Spurred by the joys of parenthood, Thomas and Karen are

I don't simply facilitate surrogacy but also play the role of psychiatrist.

NAINA PATEL, GYNAECOLOGIST



Photographs by SHAILESH RAVAL